



Refugees in Beirut. President Trump has tried to press Europe for help, but leaders there are wary of being pulled further into war.

A Presidency Characterized By ‘Epic Fury’

By PETER BAKER

WASHINGTON — By his own account, President Trump was asked to personally pick the name of the military operation against Iran and was bored by all the choices presented to him. “They gave me, like, 20 names, and I’m like, falling asleep,” he said last week. “I didn’t like any of them.”

Then at last he was offered another option: Operation Epic Fury. That woke him up. “I like that name,” he told supporters at a rally in Kentucky. “I like that name.” And so it was selected.

After all, Epic Fury captures the Trump presidency in its essence. Everything Mr. Trump does, at least as he sees it, is epic — the biggest, the most, the first, “like we’ve never seen before,” as he likes to say. And much of what he does seems to be driven by fury, a deep and abiding enmity toward the forces arrayed against him or those he blames for what he considers the downfall of the country under other presidents.

Operation Epic Fury, therefore, is a quintessentially Trumpian choice for the name of a war. Not for him an Operation Just Cause (Panama), Operation Restore Hope (Somalia), Operation Uphold Democracy (Haiti) or Operation Enduring Freedom (Afghanistan). While other military operation names in modern times have evoked broader American values or uplifting sentiments like freedom and hope, Mr. Trump prefers rage.

This is in a way the Anger Presidency. Anger defines Mr. Trump’s decade on the political stage. Anger at foreigners who come to this country and change its nature. Anger at allies who take advantage of America. Anger at Democrats who cross him. Anger at Republicans who cross him. Anger at appointees he deems insufficiently loyal. Anger at prosecutors, F.B.I. agents, judges, journalists, law firms, elite universities, cultural figures, corporate leaders, pollsters, central bankers and the Norwegian Nobel Committee.

His rally speeches, news conferences and social media feed are suffused with anger. In the past week, he attacked the “truly sick and demented people” in the

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Swirl of Intrigue Elevated a New Leader of Iran

By FARNAZ FASSIHI

Mojtaba Khamenei’s ascension as Iran’s new supreme leader might have appeared straightforward, even predestined. In fact, it was neither.

His rise came only after a full-on war of succession. The high-stakes process became the Islamic Republic’s version of “Game of Thrones”: an empty throne; a council of clerics; and two dynasties — Khamenei and Khomeini — competing. Political figures vied, military commanders defended their realms, and a former spy master known for plotting assassinations weighed in.

Even in the best of times, the task of finding Iran’s third Supreme Leader — the man who would not only represent God on earth, but wield authority over politics and the armed forces — would have been challenging. Ayatollah Ali Khamenei, after all, had ruled since 1989, through decades of tumult in the country.

But during a war with the United States and Israel, as bombs dropped from the sky and explosions rocked the earth, the selection of a successor with a lifetime appointment became a full-on test of whether the theocracy could survive.

This recounting of the inner deliberations, power plays and rivalries that thrust the ayatollah’s reclusive 56-year-old son into the leadership role is based on interviews with five senior Iranian officials, two clerics, two Iranians affiliated with the supreme leader’s office and three members of the Islamic Revolutionary Guards Corps with knowledge of the selection process. They all asked for anonymity because they were not authorized to speak publicly about internal government deliberations.

By all accounts, Mr. Khamenei most likely would not have risen if his father had died a natural

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Killing of the Ayatollah Steered Clerics in an Unlikely Direction



One Oscar After Another

Jessie Buckley (“Hamnet”) and Michael B. Jordan (“Sinners”) won for best actress and actor, while the “One Battle After Another” director Paul Thomas Anderson earned multiple awards. Page C1.



FROM LEFT, NINA WESTERVELT AND SINNA NASSERI, BOTH FOR THE NEW YORK TIMES

Mamdani Flashes Smile in Public, and Wields Sharp Elbows as Political Operator

By NICHOLAS FANDOS and SALLY GOLDENBERG

Zohran Mamdani was on the brink of completing his buoyant ascent to City Hall last November when he stepped off the campaign trail to take care of a less savory matter.

He had gotten wind that a fellow young leftist, Councilman Chi

Ossé of Brooklyn, was gearing up to challenge Representative Hakeem Jeffries, the House Democratic leader. The councilman, inspired by Mr. Mamdani’s insurgent campaign, might have expected to have his support.

But when Mr. Mamdani phoned Mr. Ossé on the eve of Election Day, the mayor-to-be was furious. He told the councilman that he

could not win, and that if he started a high-profile fight, it would undermine the left. Then the hardball started.

First, Mr. Mamdani told Mr. Ossé he would like to make him a key figure in his governing coalition — imagining the councilman at his side, for example, when he announced a new bus lane in his district — but only if he dropped

the bid, according to three people familiar with the call. Then he leveled what Mr. Ossé has described to associates as a more overt threat, saying that if his ally persisted, he would ice him out completely.

After the call ended, an email was waiting in Mr. Ossé’s inbox: His invitation to Mr. Mamdani’s victory party the next day had been rescinded.

In the year since Mr. Mamdani, 34, burst onto the city stage, he has eagerly played the part of happy warrior. Young, idealistic and self-deprecating, he appeared to soar right over New York’s cut-throat political culture on the path from obscurity to power.

But several incidents described by people close to him — including

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Wary of Split With U.S., But Haunted by the Past

Europe Resists Call to Send Ships to Iran

By MICHAEL D. SHEAR

LONDON — As President Trump’s assault on Iran enters its third week, European leaders are largely resisting his bellicose demands for help in reopening the Strait of Hormuz.

At the same time, they are trying to avoid irreparably damaging their relationship with the United States over their opposition to another war of America’s choosing.

To Mr. Trump, it should hardly be a difficult decision. He views Europe’s action — or inaction — in the face of the strait’s closure as a test of its commitment to the continent’s own security. Sending their navies for what he called a “very small endeavor” is the least that Europe’s presidents and prime ministers can do, Mr. Trump suggested over the weekend.

At an event on Monday at the White House, Mr. Trump complained that some European leaders were not showing their appreciation for everything that the United States had done to protect the continent.

“We have some countries where we have 45,000 soldiers, great soldiers, protecting them from harm’s way, and we have done a great job,” he said. “And well, we want to know, do you have any mine sweepers? ‘Well, we’d rather not get involved, sir.’”

The American president also issued a not-so-veiled warning in an interview with the Financial Times on Sunday, saying that “it will be very bad for the future of NATO” if European nations do not join the United States in its effort to reopen the vital waterway to tankers carrying oil, gas and fertilizer. At Monday’s event, he said: “I think we’re going to have some good help. And I think we’re going to be disappointed in some nations, too.”

“I’ll let you know who those nations are,” he added.

The threat was a continuation of Mr. Trump’s bullying style of diplomacy. During trade negotiations last year, the president repeatedly berated leaders who complained about his tariffs. More recently, he lashed out at Prime Minister Keir Starmer of Britain, essentially accusing him of caution and cowardice. Upon hearing that Mr. Starmer was considering sending naval ships to the Middle East, he mocked the prime minister.

“That’s OK, Prime Minister



DOUG MILLS/THE NEW YORK TIMES

The president said sending ships was a “small endeavor.”

Starmer, we don’t need them any longer,” Mr. Trump wrote on social media on March 7. “We don’t need people that join Wars after we’ve already won!”

For Mr. Trump’s counterparts around the world, the tricky part of the diplomatic dance is how to react to the president’s whims while meeting the needs of their own countries. Mr. Starmer has arguably been the European leader most eager to please Mr. Trump. And yet, on Monday, he vowed at a news conference that his country “will not be drawn

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Judge Rejects Kennedy’s Limits For Child and Covid Vaccines

By APOORVA MANDAVILLI

In a severe blow to the Trump administration’s health agenda, a federal judge in Massachusetts on Monday blocked the government from implementing a series of decisions on vaccines made over the last year by Health Secretary Robert F. Kennedy Jr.

The ruling also reversed, at least for the time being, all decisions made by the panelists that Mr. Kennedy appointed to the Advisory Committee on Immunization Practices, which makes recommendations on which vaccines Americans should take. The court decision will prevent the committee from meeting later this week, as it was scheduled to do.

The judge’s ruling abruptly halted the major changes set in motion by Mr. Kennedy, who has long been skeptical of vaccines. The secretary had upended national vaccine policy and made sweeping revisions to the recom-

mendations for what shots are given and when. Those included cutting down the number of diseases covered by routine immunization and restricting access to Covid vaccines, two pillars of Mr. Kennedy’s vaccine agenda.

In his decision, Judge Brian Murphy, of the U.S. District Court for the District of Massachusetts, noted that the vaccine committee has historically made decisions through careful review of scientific evidence, “a method scientific in nature and codified into law through procedural requirements.” But, he added, “unfortunately, the government has disregarded those methods and thereby undermined the integrity of its actions.”

The ruling by Judge Murphy, who was appointed to the federal bench by President Joseph Biden, a Democrat, will almost certainly

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Russia’s ‘Unhealthy’ Obsession

A cuddly, gentle cartoon character’s wild popularity in Russia troubles some conservatives there.

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Region’s Support for Cuba Sags

Latin America’s left once saw Cuba as its lodestar. Now leaders across the spectrum are more wary.

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NATIONAL A10-18

An Art School Trump Likes

National Endowment for the Humanities awards are flowing to handpicked projects, including millions to an institution with three employees.

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A Chef’s Fall Reverberates

In the industry where Noma’s René Redzepi reigned, his fellow chefs are debating how, and how much, restaurant kitchens can change.

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A Lever of Power for Epstein

The disgraced financier used his money and influence in the world of elite private schools to assist friends and acquaintances.

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An Early Rocketeer

Long before that step on the moon, Robert Goddard tested a liquid-fueled projectile on his aunt’s farm.

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When the Clue Is Underfoot

A group of scientists and law enforcement officials is pointing to the role moss can play in crime solving.

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A Big Home Insurance Factor

Credit history has such a stronghold on securing home insurance rates across the country that owners of identical homes can pay wildly different rates to insure them.

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Struggles at Lululemon

A corporate feud has destabilized a yoga pants empire, with interim chief executives trying to rejuvenate sales as the founder engages in a proxy battle for the boardroom.

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David French

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SPORTS B8-12

N.C.A.A. Tournament Time

Azzi Fudd, above, will be a key player for the top-seeded Connecticut women. On the men’s side, Duke is the No. 1 overall seed.

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